

TheCheeseGrater

The Other Student Magazine of University College London Union



No. 4

February 2005

THIS MONTH

NUS Referendum

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Girl finds dignity

On the pavement of Gordon Street - p.6

PLUS!

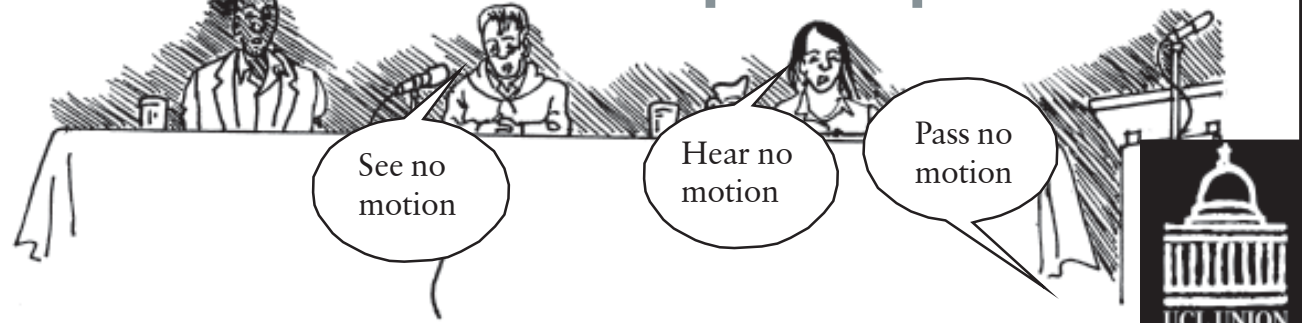
More cartoons. Tommy the Post-Nuclear Cat, Genghis the Crack Bunny and the fearsome Student Squad. From Haringey.



DAVID RENTON Under Attack

He's your Education and Welfare Officer, paid by College. And lots of people think he's crap - p.3

Union AGM Report — p.7



AT LEAST YOU COULD STILL GO AND HAVE A FAG AFTERWARDS



THE POWERS THAT BE at the Union have promised us a referendum on our affiliation to the National Union of Students, which costs us about £34,000 a year. So be it: after the mess last time, we need one. NUS is in a fix: it's dominated by self-interested factions and appears to exist only to further the political career of their president. Last year, UCL Union made a list of reforms they required of NUS, before an extraordinary conference in June. The UCL delegation took the list with them. Here it is:

1. To urge constituent members (CMs) to discuss NUS reform at their relevant student legislative body and work with the national executive committee (NEC) to reach new solutions.
2. To ensure affiliation fees represent value for money to all CMs.
3. To support proposals to make NUSSL [NUS's intermediary between businesses and its members, that supplies member Unions] membership

The Referendum

Union rats refuse to try to leave sinking ship

non-contingent on NUS membership.

4. To represent students.

5. To remove 3h and 3i from the Constitution.

6. To pursue charitable status.

7. To end factionalism in the NUS.

Union policy was: if the reforms

came, she promised that a number of reforms were 'under review', including election resources for candidates, the role of executive officers and financial expenditure. So none of what the Union asked for. Despite this minor glitch, the Union Exec has courageously decided that NUS has reformed sufficiently. There will be no 'no' campaign, and sabbs will follow their own opinions (including those who want to get elected to NUS later).

P.S. As if that wasn't bad enough, Fletcher was asked if she would promise not to be on campus to interfere during the referendum. She said she would like to be here at UCL to answer questions, like at Edinburgh, where students voted by a slim majority (52%) to join NUS and hand over £50,000.

P.P.S. For an indication of how helpful Kat Fletcher and friends were at Edinburgh, check the angry posts on the university Students' Association web forum. NUS posters claimed that NUS had abolished top-up fees in Scotland, even though this was decided by the Scottish Executive in conjunction with the Lib Dems...whose policy it had been for a while. RL



UCL Union's delegation at the NUS Extraordinary Conference in Leeds, 16-17 June 2004

were not implemented, the Union would campaign for a 'no' vote at a referendum on NUS. How times change! When NUS President Kat Fletcher met Union Executive last De-

Student Squad

from our members at DingBobik Comics
<www.freewebs.com/dingbobikcomics>



"Anything Good on TV?"



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The views expressed herein are not necessarily those of UCL Union or the editor.

UCL Union Lines Up to Kick David Renton

The Education & Welfare Officer has been denounced as lazy and incompetent by many of his colleagues. Malcolm Granger reports



The Sabbatical Suite, minus David Renton. Business as usual?

UCL STUDENT LEADERS have begun secretly briefing against the Union's Education and Welfare Officer in a bid to focus attention on a "dire" record of achievement.

David Renton, the former Anti-Racism Officer of UCL Union and current sabbatical officer, has previously been criticised by student representatives over his ambiguous stance towards membership of the National Union of Students (NUS). But in recent days, critics have intensified their anti-Renton rhetoric and alleged that he is "both apathetic and incompetent" in his management of important welfare campaigns and duties.

Several senior members of UCL Union Council, including executive officers, have cast aspersions on Renton's attitude to his job, for which College pays him about £1,000 a month. Speaking anonymously to *The Cheese Grater*, officers noted Renton's failure to attend Union meetings, his repeat-

ed and unexplained exits from meetings of College and Union committees, and his constant absence from the sabbatical office during prescribed hours of work.

"Last year a lot of people knew Alex Coles. It's not surprising that most students haven't the foggiest who David is," said one officer.

Further evidence appears to back up claims about "the ghost officer", with minutes of Campaigns Committee from September to December showing Renton's repeated failure to attend or carry out his role of Secretary, his early exit from meetings of Executive and even from an NUS briefing on the day of the handover from his predecessor. "We were talking with the President of Bristol," said one former officer. "And then David got up, yawned and said, 'Well, I'm off to get drunk.' After he walked out, we were like, 'What the hell?'"

Source after source speaks of

Renton's utter silence during most committees, including College ones. At the last meeting of the College Welfare & Equal Opportunities Committee, Renton was distinguished not only for saying nothing during the two-hour session, but for antagonising a staff member before the meeting by claiming he had not been sent a copy of the agenda, and subsequently walking out early. Whilst staff members of the College declined to comment about Renton's committee style, some officers with college contacts strongly suggest that he is widely derided in official circles. "He doesn't say anything, he doesn't put anything on the agenda, he doesn't follow anything up with the College. Is it any wonder he's a joke to them?"

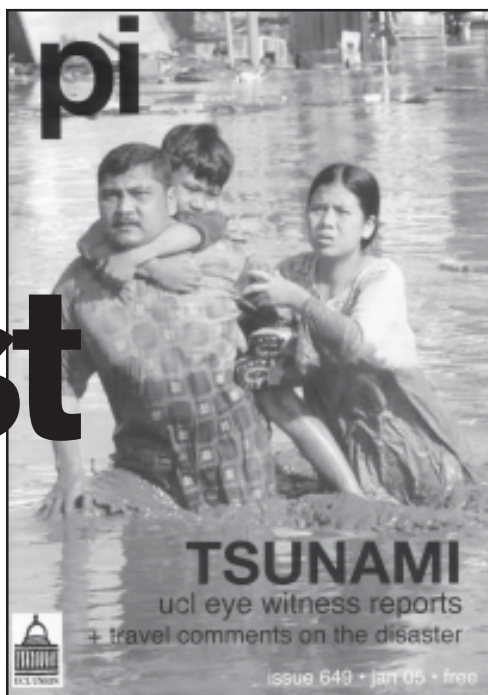
In the last two weeks, there has been increasing speculation as to whether Renton wishes to mount an electoral bid for the National Executive Committee (NEC) of the NUS. *The Cheese Grater* can state that these rumours are false and in response to an email inquiry, Renton claimed: "I first 'found out' that I was standing when a friend of mine told me to look at EdNet.". Renton's failure to quickly quash these rumours seems to have provoked his domestic critics at UCL Union into acting against him.

A no-confidence procedure is notoriously difficult to carry out against a serving Sabbatical Officer, and thus far no-one has mentioned any attempt to do so. But if criticism of such a high-ranking student union leader continues – and he refuses to address these complaints – then the many critics of UCL Union will continue to delight in attacking the E&W record. And that does not bode well for the next holder of that position.

Comments on this story to our e-mail address opposite

It doesn't do us justice. It's no place for student journalists to hone their skills. It's under the thumb of sabbatical officers, and it's as exciting as a cheese sandwich. In its current form...

Pi Must Die



IN THE EDITORIAL to the latest issue of *Pi* on January 24th, student editor Holly Falconer had exciting news. At a meeting of UCL Union Council on 6 December, there had been “a motion that would disaffiliate *Pi* from the Union...this motion was put forward by a certain ex-news editor of *Pi*...who visibly cringed as he walked past *Pi* editors...on his way into the meeting”. Fortunately, she reassured us, the *Pi* staff united under their editor to ensure that the motion was not passed. “Other motions put forward by this ‘mystery man’ and his friends were to create a separate MC officer whose sole responsibility would be *Pi*, disregarding the costs of such a proposition. Also, it was suggested we should scrap your beloved scrapbook as it was deemed immoral...”

This grossly misleading piece, apparently motivated by animosity towards the ‘mystery man’ (Dex Torricke-Barton) obscured the intent behind what was in fact just one motion: to reform *Pi*. *Pi* is a disgrace to us. It has failed completely and consistently to hold the Union to account. *Pi* is crying out for a rethink. But its editors have thus far blocked all attempts to

change the status quo, while a large number of staff are alleged to have quit this year.

Pi and the rest

Pi as it is now is overseen by a ‘chief editor’, the Media and Communications Officer (currently Alex Walsh). She is a sabbatical officer and a member of Union Executive. Beneath her is a ‘student editor’ and a ‘deputy editor’. But why? The system is practically unique. *London Student*, the other publication most visible to UCL students, has a sabb at its head too, but they are not an executive officer of the Union — their sole concern is to publish. Imperial College Union’s *Felix* has the same. The LSE Students’ Union paper *The Beaver* has a student editor in charge. *Roar* at King’s College is unusual in using the same system as *Pi*.

That’s not the only difference that sets UCL apart. Why is there no weekly newspaper? The LSE and Imperial, who make up the Golden Triangle of top-rank institutions with UCL and Oxbridge, both have one. *London Student* and *Roar* compromise with a fortnightly issue. Some colleges (LSE and Imperial again) publish both a

newspaper and a less frequent magazine, thus allowing students to help create both formats.

But here at UCL, for all our money-grabbing campaigns; for all our annual turnover; for all our status as a contender on the global HE stage, all our students can cough up is one monthly magazine. And the magazine is enough to make you weep.

The state of *Pi*

Responsibility for *Pi*’s content lies with the student body; the layout, last time we looked, was done by the M & C Officer. While some of the articles are good, many are badly written and crushingly boring (a *pensée* on CO2 emissions laws, anyone?) Articles appear to be used out of desperation rather than choice (the December issue featured ‘how to microwave a light bulb’, an inadvisable thing to do). Without attacking individual writers, it has to be said that the standard of writing is often poor and sloppily done. Until *Pi*’s staff learn how to punctuate, spell their own names right and discover the difference between ‘affected’ and ‘effected’ (to name but one clanger) nobody can or should take them seriously.

Layout and design are, if anything, worse than the content. *Pi*’s fundamental appearance has not changed for over a year. Practically everything is printed in one unattractive typeface (Switzerland), which being sans serif is harder on the eye. Text and graphics jostle indecorously for space on the page, and columns can be idiotically broken up by oddly-shaped pictures. The images themselves are often pixelated, suggesting that they have been culled from the Internet at the last minute. Student publications can look good, as Imperial College’s *Felix* demonstrates. None of these faults, however is as worrying as *Pi*’s complete lack of editorial independence. And if you don’t think *Pi* gets censored, think again.

Pi Gagged

Under Alex Walsh’s tenure, stories for *Pi* have disappeared or been cut. Last August a UCL student jumped to

their death from the Engineering building; *London Student* reported it, but *Pi* was silent. A then *Pi* staffer told *The Cheese Grater* that Prof. John Foreman, the Dean of Students, wanted the story removed. A story about UCL Union's Christian Union was removed to spare the society's officers embarrassment, and an article on Ted Honderich by Dex Torricke-Barton was heavily cut at the instigation of Education and Welfare officer David Renton. So much, then, for *Pi*'s objectivity. Hardly surprising that a few of the staff got restless.

Pi Eaten from Within

One such person was *Pi* news editor Dex Torricke-Barton (not a man whom this magazine has gone out of its way to praise - see issue 2). After his Honderich article was cut, Dex told a *Pi* meeting they had to reform. When this was ignored, he left and, by his account, took eight of *Pi*'s news reporters with him to *LS*, leaving Andrew Ridge to run the show. *Pi* newsman James Brady declined to comment to *The Cheese Grater*, suggesting the story is not entirely untrue. The put-

Pi Survey		No. surveyed: 40
Do you read <i>Pi</i>?		
Never	20%	
Occasionally	27.5%	
Almost every issue	25%	
Every issue	22.5%	
How many pages?		
More than half	37.5%	
Less than half	35%	
2 or less	5%	
Average marks out of 5:		1.7

upon news desk had to make up extra author names for their articles: 'Steven Scott' and 'James Evans' have written a lot for *Pi*, but they don't seem to be in the College directory. Dex describes his new job as *LS* news editor as a 'promotion'.

In December, Dex and others presented their 'Vibrant Media' motion to UCL Union Council. Contrary to Falconer's editorial, it didn't require for 'a separate MC officer'; it merely encouraged the creation of a sabbatical editor post for *Pi*. Nor did it call the scrapbook immoral; it simply said

it painted a crude and unintellectual portrait of UCL students. While it required *Pi* to be disaffiliated, there is nothing wrong with that. *Pi* is not a normal society; it is under no risk of suspension or disaffiliation, its funds are assured and its officers don't often bother to turn up to Arts Board. Dex did indeed resign at this meeting; so did Olivier Usher. The media motion was heavily amended by Frankie Roberto (who might possibly have wanted to curry favour with the *Pi* staff, as he intends to run for M & C Officer) and passed without any changes to *Pi*.

So it is unlikely that *Pi* will change, but change it must if it is to fulfil its obligations to us, the students. It must be made independent from the Union Executive, to resolve the M & C Officer's massive and glaringly obvious conflict of interest.

And finally: for the last time, the fact that Jonathan Dimpleby used to edit *Pi* is not evidence of what it can do for your career. Dimpleby owes his job to the fact that his father Richard was a BBC broadcaster. And besides, he's not even very good. RL

..... Heaven accused of 'dumbing down'

Is Paradise lowering standards in the race for inclusiveness?

Nikolai Morofski

A REPORT commissioned by Associated Churches has found that Heaven has significantly lowered its entrance requirements. Comparing Heaven's gate policy of the 21st century with only five hundred years ago showed a marked 1000% increase in those allowed into Heaven, even after adjusting for population density. "It used to be harder for a rich man to get into Heaven than for a camel to pass through an eye of a needle," said one dismayed theist. "Now anyone who has made a donation to the tsunami appeal or ever helped an old lady across the street is practically guaranteed a place." The report concludes the marked increase is due to generations

of philosophies and sciences that mitigate people's responsibility for their actions. Whereas before, Heaven made a decision based on the number and gravity of sins committed by persons, new government guidelines demand it take into account the background of the souls. Their socio-ethic background must all be considered. In addition, Heaven is no longer allowed to discriminate on the basis of race, gender, sexuality, genetics or even the religion of the person. All these added factors almost entirely rule out any personal moral responsibility.

"The only people we still refused into Heaven are murderers, rapists and journalists; but our policy on murderers is currently under review," St Peter announced as he looked over a

clearing application for a suicide bomber who was guaranteed a place in heaven when still on the earth. The rise in entrants has also corresponded to a higher dropout rate.

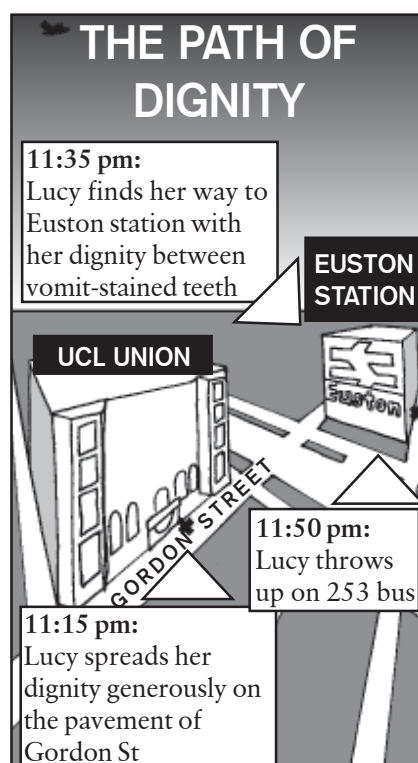
"People seem to assume that Heaven is a place for everyone," Satan's official spokesman said, "but this is simply not the case...[a late homosexual] recently returned to my flock after explaining that the sort of ecstasy given to him in Heaven was not for him (*He should have gone to the other Heaven, where it can be obtained for little, if anything — Ed.*). In modern times, when people have very different conceptions of the good, remember that we offer a wide variety of Afterlife solutions. Many will achieve and enjoy themselves more in Hell."

Girl finds dignity on side of pavement

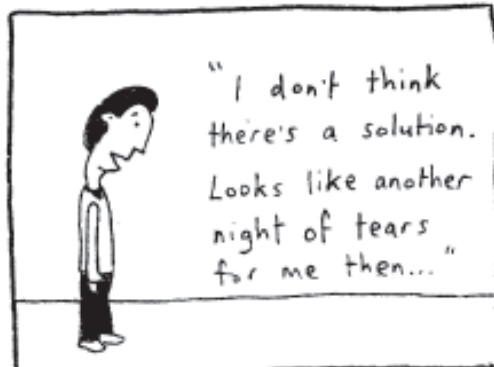
WORLD EXCLUSIVE by
Rusty Wood

FOLLOWING a worrying 10 minutes in which she thought she had lost it forever, Lucy Hutch successfully found her dignity floating away in her sick that adorned the side of the pavement on Gordon Street. Lucy's support network of inebriated, shouting girlfriends rallied round as soon as she realised that it had gone missing and together they successfully exploited a group of first year hopefuls by promising to 'make it up to them'. One of these boys, Justin Bitmore from Naples, luckily stumbled across and fell into Lucy's regurgitated stomach lining, peppered with sweetcorn and spaghetti hoops. Lucy's dignity was

successfully fished out and returned to her, before she promptly threw it up again on the bus (253) home. Transport for London have said they have not found Lucy's dignity, citing the possibility that it seeped out of the back door when the girls were thrown off the bus. When asked if the current state of leglessness that prevails amongst women in UCL Union was a bad thing for the College's image, Clubs, Societies & Student Development Officer Liz Oglesby promptly ignored the question and continued to pull out the bacon bits from her hair. A memento of last night, surely.



DVD



bird <www.angelfire.com/nd2/bird/>
You can email him at <smilingblamety@hotmail.com> to obtain copies of
his latest comic, "Sizemo and Satchmo versus Humanity" at £1.00 each

THE PRIVATE LIFE OF STUDENTS

*A personal view of
a fascinating species
by **David
Attenborough***

Episode 12: The Union AGM



A triumphant Attenborough after discovering no less than 22 of the rare breed of 'student politician', in an otherwise prosperous and well-adjusted area of central London.

Attenborough: This... is the UCL Bloomsbury Theatre. I'm crouching behind one of these crates of orange Reef outside the bar, and trying to keep quiet, because I don't want to disturb the very, very rare creatures who, every year, make this place their home.

And here they come. Here, in the heart of thousands of ordinary people, live a tiny offshoot of the species, known as the 'student politicians'. And within this group lives an even smaller pack. These are the extremely rare breed of student politician who, every year, perform the arcane ritual called an 'Annual General Meeting'.

And there's another one! That's two so far.

It seems that the sheer smallness of this sub-species, whose only physical characteristic is a small, flat, rectangular pink appendage to the hand, is down to natural selection. These creatures are simply incapable of adapting to the pressures of life outside in the open. And so, they take shelter in familiar, protective surroundings, such as this dark, musty theatre, or in the spaces between the lever arch files in the minutes archive on the fourth floor of 25 Gordon Street. And now, I'll be very quiet, because I think one of the

dominant males - a proud, aggressive macho figure - is about to speak.

Nigel Harris: Hello...

Attenborough: This is a member of the dominant faction, who control all the student politicians' activities. Whilst virtually unheard of and ignored by the greater species, they are a huge and domineering presence among the student politicians. To reinforce the closed nature of their tribal group, they communicate in an obscure language which has baffled all attempts at decipherment. It is called 'standing orders'. For a dominant sub-species member to talk in 'standing orders' is to signal to their inferiors that this is a matter they cannot understand, let alone control.

But wait! I think one of the inferior creatures is actually about to reply to the dominant male - to challenge him!

Pei Chi Wong: I want to call quorum.

Attenborough: And, the effect is astounding. The dominant species are cowed. The strange, irrational force

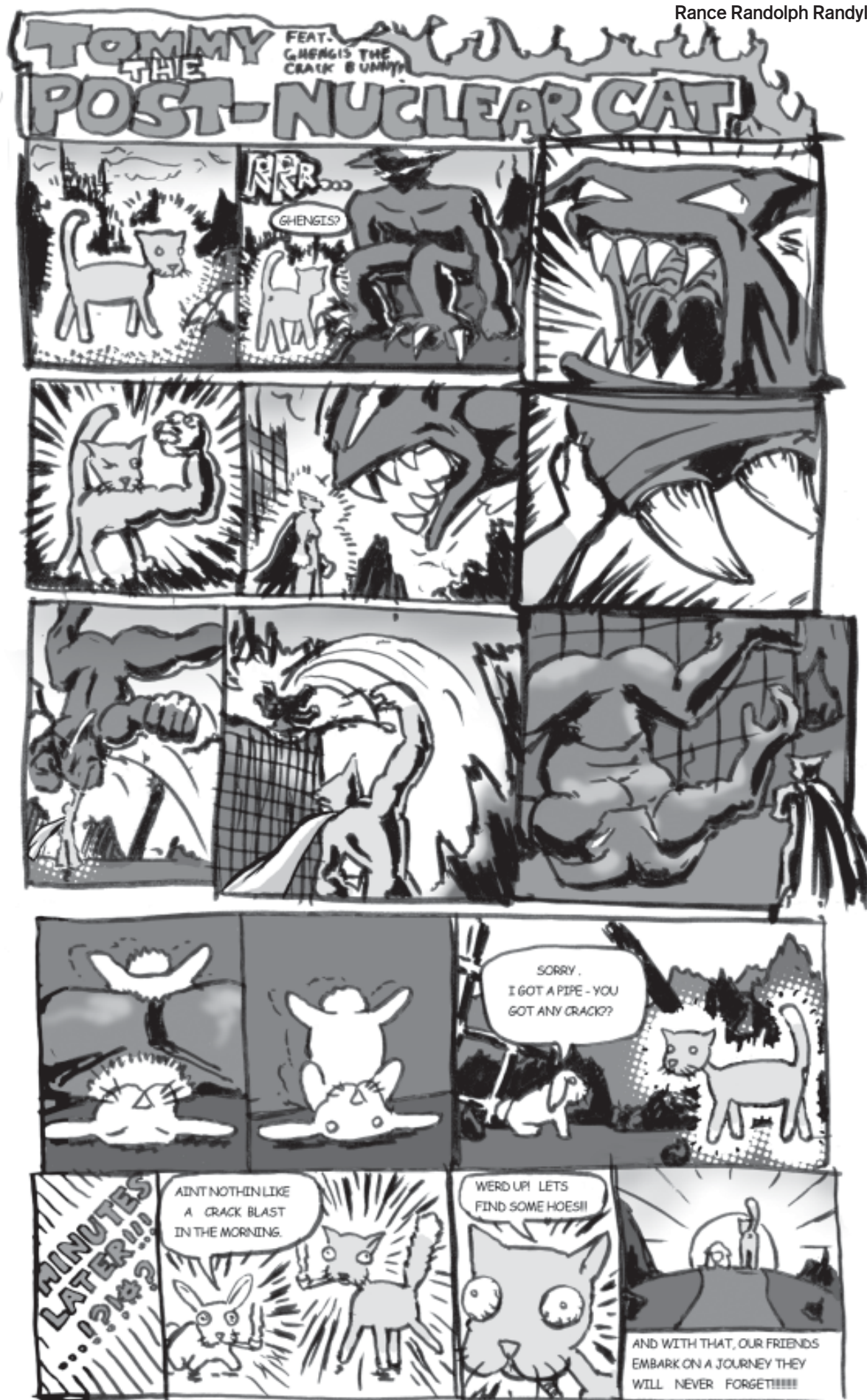
of this call has an almost mesmerizing effect. Some of the student politicians clearly look relaxed; they're standing up and, yes, moving towards the nearest fire exit. Others, however, are looking with hostility at the upstart species member. Nobody can say for sure what these rituals mean. But despite their apparent irrelevance to anything else going on anywhere, this dogged breed continues its activities year after year. Some say that it is a way of gaining favour and influence within the species. But if this is all they know how to do, how can they progress to any real-world environment?



'I'm sorry, darling, but you can't load another war. That was the television news, not your Xbox.'

Rance Randolph Randylin

This is a new version of a cartoon done by one of our members that originally appeared on the web - Ed.



Contributors to this issue: Nikolai Morofski, Scary Boots, Rusty Wood, Malcolm Granger, Ding and Bobik, Rance Randolph Randylin (Engineering with Swedish 1973), bird.